

In the middle of it, with everyone watching

6 findings · 13-step checklist · 1 myth · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

What's spiking hardest right now isn't her tantrum, it's standing in front of strangers while it happens. Fewer of them will notice or remember this than it feels like.

THE GOAL

You're getting her through the meltdown, and that's the only job here. Keep both hands and your eyes on her until it passes.

CHECKLIST

You're mid-tantrum with her in a public place, and people nearby can see and hear what's happening.

- ☐ Get a hand or arm around her so she can't bolt into the aisle or hurt herself, then stay put.
- ☐ Set down or hand off whatever's in your other hand, bag or cart, so both hands are free for her.
- ☐ If someone nearby is in the way or comments, give one short line, like 'we're okay, just a minute,' then **turn back to her**.
- ☐ Keep your eyes and attention on her, not on who might be watching or what they're thinking.
- ☐ Stop trying to reason, explain, or bargain with her until she's past the peak of the crying.
- ☐ Get down to her level or pick her up if she'll allow it, and keep your own breathing slow.
- ☐ If she pushes you away, stay close without grabbing at her, and let her come back to you.
- ☐ Once the crying softens into sniffing, say a short comfort line and **open your arms**; that's the moment she'll take it.
- ☐ Once she's calm enough to stand, decide right then: finish what you came for or leave, whichever gets you both out faster.
- ☐ If you're leaving, say out loud where you're going before you move, like 'we're walking to the car now.'
- ☐ Once you're both away from the spot, take one slow breath before you do anything else.
- ☐ Note somewhere handy what set it off, just to keep for later, not to solve right now.
- ☐ Pick the errand back up from where you left off, not from the beginning.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** What's spiking hardest right now isn't the tantrum. It's **the threat to how competent you look as a parent** in front of strangers.
- 2** The number of people who will notice and remember this scene is roughly half of what you're picturing right now.
- 3** Nearly every parent of a young child deals with a meltdown like this at some point: in one survey, about 95 percent said their child has thrown at least one tantrum.

What being watched is doing to you

KNOW

What's spiking hardest right now isn't the tantrum. It's **the threat to how competent you look as a parent** in front of strangers.

This research found the biggest stress-hormone spikes when people are watched and unable to control the situation, both true right now. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

The number of people who will notice and remember this scene is roughly half of what you're picturing right now.

You're anchored on how obvious this feels to you, and that anchor **doesn't get adjusted down enough** for what others noticed. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

How rattled you look on the outside is nowhere near as obvious as how rattled you feel on the inside.

People who lied or felt a disgust they were hiding consistently overestimated how much of it leaked onto their face for onlookers. [Source 4](#)

What's true about this specific tantrum

DON'T

Don't try to reason with her mid-tantrum.

The anger burns itself out into something softer, and that's when she'll take your comfort, not before. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Nearly every parent of a young child deals with a meltdown like this at some point: in one survey, about 95 percent said their child has thrown at least one tantrum.

Out of 211 families surveyed, all but a handful reported at least one tantrum, crying and shouting being the most common forms it took. [Source 5](#)

RULE

Most tantrums at this age run their course in well under fifteen minutes, whatever it feels like while you're in the middle of one.

One survey found only about 10 percent of children's tantrums lasted past the fifteen-minute mark. [Source 5](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

If your child never melts down like this in front of people, it's because you're doing something right, and if she does, you're not.

ACTUALLY

A specific tantrum happening in front of people isn't a report card on the parent standing there. It's a normal, expected part of this age, **not a skill some parents have and others don't.** [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.psychologytoday.com/nz/blog/parenting-from-a-neuroscience-perspective/202002/tantrums-meltdowns-and-everything-in-between>
2. https://www.psychiatry.wisc.edu/courses/Nitschke/seminar/dickerson_kemeny_metaanalysis%202004%20psych%20bull.pdf
3. <https://www.simplypsychology.com/articles/spotlight-effect-psychology>
4. http://www.communicationcache.com/uploads/1/0/8/8/10887248/the_illusion_of_transparency_biased_assessments_of_others_ability_to_read_ones_emotional_states.pdf
5. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11825109/>
6. <https://www.zerotothree.org/resource/pro-tips-for-managing-toddler-tantrums/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Little children and big feelings at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)